

U.S. Software

Positive June Quarter Cyber Checks, but Not a Step Change

Equities

Americas
Software

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Summary

Across conversations with 6 partners and 3 customers, our checks support a view that cybersecurity remains one of the healthiest and most resilient areas of enterprise technology spending. We see enterprise concerns over AI's impact on the threat environment supporting cybersecurity budget growth over the next twelve months. That said, our field work highlighted modestly better 2Q performance across partner practices, and not necessarily a step change in demand. Net, with cybersecurity stocks up an average 20% MTD and nearly 80% since April 10th, we think the setup for the sector into 2Q earnings looks challenging.

What we heard

Across 6 partners, 5 cited above-plan 2Q results, with 1 citing deal delays in May/June. Consistent with prior quarters we heard the most positivity around larger vendors like **CRWD** and **PANW**, however June quarter checks sounded more well-rounded. While most of the partners we spoke with cited rather small vuln mgmt practices, anecdotal feedback on **TENB/QLYS** was upbeat. Customers spoke to better budget availability but suggested spend is still being scrutinized and it seems like some organizations are contemplating transformational security projects with longer sales cycles. Overall, conversations suggested that pace of vulnerabilities/incidents, growing regulatory requirements, and reputational risks of AI security incidents will continue to drive board-level awareness and support for cybersecurity. In firewall, we heard mostly positive feedback on the June quarter and July pipeline, but some concerns that some of the strength has come from the 2H pipeline.

Priorities & Deal Timelines

Checks suggest AI security and AI governance remain top of mind, with identity, data security, and security analytics (SIEM) also popping up in nearly every conversation. We heard similar support for cloud security, endpoint, and mixed views on SASE and cyber resilience. Vendor consolidation also remains a recurring theme, with customers increasingly looking to simplify security architectures and standardize around strategic platforms. However, we heard some examples of enterprises buying standalone AI security. Firewall, which was acknowledged as solid in 2Q, was not cited as a key beneficiary from AI. Consistent with our prior work we heard more interest in zero-trust microsegmentation strategies and SASE solutions, which are more strategic projects. While our conversations were broadly constructive on demand and spending trends, a few customers and partners noted delayed purchasing decisions, renewal pushouts, and longer approval cycles. While checks mostly sounded positive (and support multi-quarter/year tailwinds for the space), we don't think stocks are priced for any weakness in deal timing. We include more commentary below.

Cybersecurity Demand & Budgets

Our checks suggest cybersecurity remains one of the most resilient areas of enterprise technology spending despite a more uncertain macro backdrop. Two customers described cybersecurity as a protected area of spending that continues to receive executive- and board-level support, with one customer reporting security budget growth materially outpacing broader IT spending. Partner commentary was also broadly constructive, with four partners characterizing demand as healthy, strong, or above plan during the quarter. While one customer and two partners noted delayed purchasing decisions, renewal pushouts, or elongated sales cycles, the overarching takeaway remains that cybersecurity budgets and spending priorities continue to hold up well relative to broader IT spending trends.

Customer #1: Traditional IT budgets broadly across the automotive industry are going to be stagnant to maybe down as we face some severe headwinds. This is leading to us focusing AI initiatives to do more with less. But we are getting no additional budget to fund AI, so we are funding it through cost optimization and cost take out elsewhere. But when it comes to our cybersecurity budgets, that will continue to be well funded. For us, cyber budgets come from the executive level as it is an emphasized reputational risk. Two of our providers saw ransomware attacks just this last quarter where their entire database was locked. So, when things like this continue to happen, cyber will be funded irrespective of what happens at the broader IT budget level.

Customer #2: We saw our total IT budget increase high-single digits, but our cybersecurity budget increased more than 15% with the introduction of some zero-trust initiatives and SASE, which were quite big, then also some on pen testing. All in all, this was a very big investment from our end, and considering our industry, and us specifically, have faced several attacks over the past years. So, with this being such a big concern for us, the overall security aspect, physical and cyber security, is a board initiative with dedicated capex.

Customer #3: Most of the Anthropic Mythos news is not hype. We are seeing the amount of attack paths increase a lot. We have seen attacks become more complex with personalized emails. We are also exploring vulnerabilities in windows systems. That said, we are still evaluating a few deals. I have absolutely seen security projects paused or delayed. It has been a challenge.

Partner #1: With June, we had a really strong finish to our Q2, it is very much the busy season. Looking back, April buying behavior was very interesting. It felt like everybody was kind of frantic but not doing anything in terms of actual product sale or consulting work. So, I would say that April and May were slow, then June was extremely strong, which got us to slightly above plan for the quarter. Mythos didn't cause a COVID like reaction where everyone went remote overnight and POs just came raining from the sky because everyone needed to support remote work. It feels very different than that. But I think Mythos accelerated a lot of those AI security initiatives that were going through diligence phases, cycles of analysis, and proofs of concept. I think it kind of got some of those projects unstuck, which we are seeing now with like those July deals and enterprise agreements often include AI Defense if it's a Cisco deal or Prisma AIRs for Palo Alto.

Partner #2: Security demand overall was pretty healthy from our pipeline perspective. I think it is one of the hottest areas, to be honest. But I would not attribute it as a material step change from the first quarter to the second. I see it more so as a continuation of that strong demand, which I think has been building over the last couple of years. What I see is that security at the moment is a board-level priority. So even when customers are scrutinizing that discretionary spending, I think cybersecurity is a very protected budget. In terms of cyber areas that are of strongest demand, I would say cloud security, IAM, cyber resilience, MDR, data security, and more and more AI security and governance. AI has created a new set of concerns around data protection, model governance, access controls, and even regulatory compliance, so there is incremental investment being created. We are seeing customers look to consolidate vendors and simplify their security operating models more so in light of this. So, there is more focus on evaluating a platform like Microsoft, Palo Alto, CrowdStrike, Zscaler, and Okta. But despite no dramatic acceleration happening from quarter to quarter, I would describe this

environment as strong. It is strong demand and cyber will continue to be a resilient area from a tech spending perspective, especially in the large customers where you see a complex threat landscape and regulatory expectation to add the weight.

Partner #3: I think 2Q was fairly strong. Cybersecurity, as a whole, is showing no signs of weakness with the exception of appliance-based firewalls, which is still very much growing, just not to the same extent as some of these other solutions. In my view, that is the subsegment that is facing some pressure for a variety of reasons, legacy technology, and other things. But other than that, across the board, identity, data security, all the security elements from a cloud perspective ranging from CNAPP, CWPP, CSPM, and then EDR, XDR, SOC, SecOps in general are seeing maximum traction from an AI elevation standpoint. Also, SASE continues to grow well. So for the most part, cybersecurity has been able to hold its growth trajectory in 2Q, as the business came in well above our growth expectations.

Partner #4: We had a positive 2Q, we achieved all our targets but there are certainly some areas of cybersecurity growing better than others, especially regarding AI security. But overall, our cybersecurity practice grew around double-digits, a couple points above the growth expectation we had.

Partner #5: The business across the board during May and June just went flat for Q2. So Q2 wasn't an acceleration off of Q1. We saw the security business really pick up Q4 last year, and Q1 was good, and April went well. Then all of a sudden customers just stopped purchasing. They stopped their renewals, they started pushing deals back and delaying as much as they can right now. We have one large customer doing tiny extensions every month. I am not sure if its customers trying to preserve cash flow, the fact that a lot of customers moved forward their budget to buy whatever hardware they could that was available due to chip shortages and memory prices, or because of the larger geopolitical and macro environment, but from talking to peers this seems to be a trend others are seeing.

Partner #6: We have seen some very good growth in 2Q. It still picked up and went very strong. In June, there was a little drop, but nothing too serious. 1Q was amazing. There was massive revenue coming in from the public space. I noticed a huge progress in sales. And this could be majorly because of the AI innovation that is going on in the market. In Fed, there have been several major GPOs releasing RFPs for AI enterprise agreements. So, yes, we are seeing very high growth this year compared to where we were last year, and Q2 was above plan.

Cybersecurity Priorities

AI security and governance emerged as the most consistent security priority across our checks, with two customers and multiple partners discussing growing focus on AI governance, access controls, and broader security requirements tied to AI adoption. Vendor consolidation was another recurring theme, with two customers and two partners highlighting efforts to simplify security architectures and concentrate spending with strategic platforms. Notably, one customer and one partner specifically indicated organizations are increasingly looking to existing vendors first when evaluating AI security capabilities, suggesting incumbent platforms may have an early advantage as spending in the category develops. More broadly, identity, data security, security analytics, endpoint and cloud security, were consistently cited as areas receiving the strongest customer attention and investment.

Customer #1: There is a school of thought that we should continue to consolidate to our strategic vendors which are Palo Alto, CrowdStrike, and Wiz. However, what is larger priority right now from a security perspective as we try to really focus on leveraging AI for broader IT cost saving is to ensure that our AI governance and zero trust access control is implemented.

Customer #2: When looking to secure AI, we are first looking to our existing partners. So, for example, we will look to Salesforce, ServiceNow, or even SAP, and then if the requirement is not met by them, we will start considering point solutions or open source. This is the same with security vendors. We have CrowdStrike for both cloud and endpoint and will most likely go to them first.

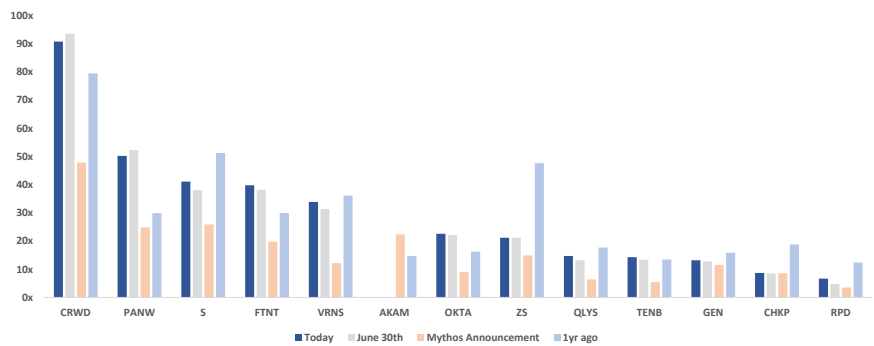
Customer #3: There is a focus for sure on vendor consolidation, however the risk of lock-in is definitely a consideration. We need to prepare nowadays, as we have a lot of regulatory requirements and need to upgrade tools for AI.

Partner #1: A lot of those platform plays seem to be the first step that organizations are taking because they are comfortable with the brand, they have a license agreement, and they have negotiated commercial relationships. So, all of this makes sense why we are seeing a good amount of success with product extensions. Interestingly enough, we have sold some Prompt Security to non-SentinelOne accounts as well as we have had some non-firewall Check Point customers buy Lakera.

Partner #2: I think customers are showing less appetite for highly specialized stand-alone tools, unless they need to solve a very specific problem. Then all this budget and operational complexity is pushing customers towards broader platforms who can offer integrated complexities. I think vendors who align with the consolidation theme, cloud security, identity, cyber resilience, and AI governance appear to have much better demand tailwinds at the moment.

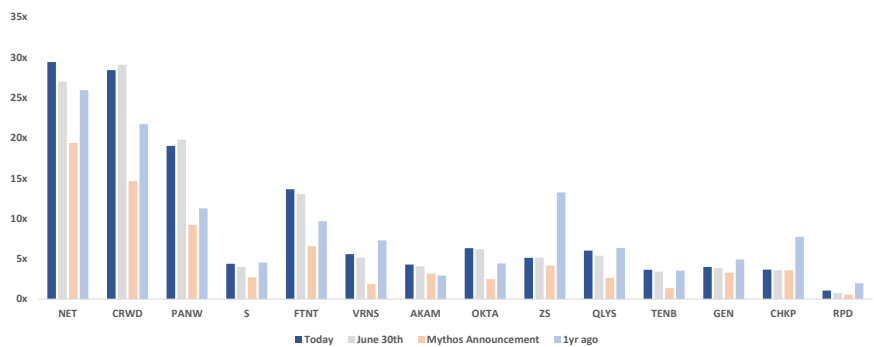
Cybersecurity Valuations

Figure 1: NTM EV/FCF



Source: FactSet

Figure 2: NTM EV/Sales



Source: FactSet

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Investing in the technology sector entails above-average risk given low sales visibility, rapid pace of innovation and technological change, intense competition, frequent M&A, and low barriers to entry in many markets.

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Fortinet Inc ^{16,28}	FTNT.O	Neutral	US\$160.62	13 Jul 2026
Palo Alto Networks ^{4,16,6}	PANW.O	Neutral	US\$330.30	13 Jul 2026
Qualys, Inc. ^{16,28}	QLYS.O	Neutral	US\$151.54	13 Jul 2026
SentinelOne Inc ^{13,16,28}	S.N	Neutral	US\$18.55	13 Jul 2026
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